

Dhāraṇī Called Cultivating Wisdom

Prajñāvardhanī Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 718 · Derge Kangyur

ཤེས་རབ་སྒྲོལ་པའི་གཟུངས།

Toh 718 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in Sanskrit as the Prajñāvardhanī Nāma Dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as the Shes rab sgong ba zhes bya ba'i gzungs, meaning "The Dhāraṇī Called Cultivating Wisdom." It belongs to the general class of dhāraṇī literature, presenting a sacred formula intended to sharpen the memory and deepen the wisdom of practitioners whose understanding is dull or unsteady, with the text specifying that reciting the mantra over food and consuming it will ensure that whatever one has heard is retained without forgetting. The text is set on the slope of Mount Meru, where the bodhisattva Matimān teaches the Dharma to an assembly of divine sons, and a great bodhisattva of youthful form then requests the teaching on behalf of beings with weak and wandering minds. As a relatively brief dhāraṇī sūtra, it sits within the broader collection of dhāraṇī and mantra scriptures preserved in the Kangyur.

If one recites this mantra over food and eats it, one will without fail retain what one has heard. This concludes the dhāraṇī called "Non-Forgetting."

In the language of India: Prajñāvardhanī Nāma Dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: the dhāraṇī called "Cultivating Wisdom." Homage to the omniscient one.

Thus did I hear. At one time, the Blessed One, the bodhisattva Intelligent One (Matimān), was dwelling on the slope of Mount Meru, and, surrounded by all the divine sons residing on Mount Meru, was teaching the Dharma before them.

Then the great bodhisattva of youthful form pressed his palms together and addressed the bodhisattva Intelligent One and the rest, saying: "Blessed One, for the sake of sentient beings whose wisdom is dull, whose understanding is weak, and whose minds are unsteady, please expound the dhāraṇī called 'Cultivating Wisdom.'"

The teaching was then given:

Hūṃ picu picu. Prajñāvardhanī jvala jvala. Medhāvardhanī. Dhiri dhiri. Buddhivardhanī svāhā.

Whoever holds this dhāraṇī, recites it, writes it, has it written, or, even as a child, hears as much as a single syllable of it — in that very lifetime they will

come to possess great wisdom.

Whoever, for a period of six months, each day recites this incantation seven times over a bowlful of water stirred with a root and drinks it at sunrise will retain a thousand thousand verses. Drinking it once, one retains five hundred, and each day wisdom will increase. By simply reciting it once each day, mindfulness and mental stability will arise.

This concludes the dhāraṇī called "Cultivating Wisdom."

Translated by the Indian master Jñānagarbha and the translator-monk Nagendrā. Revised and established by the Indian master Vidyākarasiṃha and the great-revision translator-monk Devacandra.

Translator's Notes

- The passage opens mid-text with "If one recites this mantra over food and eats it," closing out an earlier dhāraṇī called "Non-Forgetting" before the colophon of the present text begins. This abrupt opening is faithful to the Tibetan as given, which begins in medias res.

The bodhisattva "Intelligent One" renders the Tibetan blo ldan, which corresponds to a Sanskrit name such as Matimān or Medhāvin; neither a canonical Sanskrit equivalent nor a well-known figure by this name is firmly established, so this rendering is tentative.

The phrase "a bowlful of water stirred with a root" renders rtsa bas khyor gang, literally "a bowl stirred with a root." The exact identity of the root is unspecified in the text.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.